

## Moral luck



Is a drink-driver who kills someone in a crash morally worse than one who by chance happens not to?

Modern philosophers have identified a problem with the idea of judging the rightness of an action by either its consequences or the motives behind it. Circumstances beyond our control can and do affect the outcome of our actions, often dramatically. Actions taken with the best of intentions may result in disaster, and it is not easy to judge the morality of, for example, a seemingly harmless prank that causes injury, or conversely a self-serving

act that unintentionally brings prosperity to others. We may also blame or criticize actions that result from circumstances different from our own, such as the inhumanity of slave-owners, without knowing how any of us would have behaved in the same situation.

Moral judgement turns out to be far more complex than the simple assessment of consequences or even motives, raising questions such as what part chance plays in determining if an action is good or bad – is there such a thing as ‘moral luck’? And is it bad to be unlucky, or even unlucky to be bad?